

Democrats are now narrow Senate favorites

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Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

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Eurasia Group now gives Democrats a slight edge to win a Senate majority (55% odds), driven by a substantial shift in the generic congressional ballot and sustained polling leads for the party in crucial states.

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If Democrats flip North Carolina as expected and hold all their current seats, they will need to win three of five key races—out of Maine, Texas, Ohio, Alaska, and Iowa—to claim the Senate majority, with weaker-than-expected polling in Michigan, New Hampshire, and Minnesota leaving them as only narrow favorites.

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While Democratic control of the Senate in addition to the House would not have major policy ramifications over the course of 2027 and 2028, beyond holding up White House nominations for executive and judicial positions, winning the Senate this year would give Democrats a head start on retaining control in 2028.

Eurasia Group now sees Democrats as the slight favorites to win the Senate (55% odds). In our previous update, we said we would revise our views on the race if the generic ballot shifted to D+8.5 percentage points, President Donald Trump's approval fell below 36%, or if Democrats retained polling leads into late September (see United States: "Republicans retain razor-thin lead in Senate race," 8 September 2026). That last signpost has now clearly been hit, and Democrats are on the verge of the first as well; in Silver Bulletin's all-voter version of the generic congressional ballot, Democrats lead by 8.1 points, and by 8.8 points after applying a likely-voter filter.

A unified Democratic Congress is now our basecase for 2027-2028. If Democrats win the Senate, the conditional probability of winning the House is nearly 100%; the party can probably win the Senate only in a strongly left-leaning national environment that would almost certainly see it flip the House as well. Our 85% odds that Democrats win the House mean that we functionally assign 55% odds to a unified Democratic Congress, 30% odds to a split Congress (Democratic House, Republican Senate), and 15% odds to a unified Republican Congress.

Recent macro developments and polling in key races support a slight Democratic advantage. At the national level, the gas price spike this month is as close to political kryptonite as it can get for the party in power. Its effects are reverberating downballot; each of the races on which Senate control depends—Maine, Texas, Ohio, Alaska , and Iowa—looks less like a toss-up than it did before Labor Day.

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In Texas, Democrat James Talarico has led in all but one poll since late June. This race now tilts slightly toward Democrats despite Texas's Republican lean.

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In Ohio, Republican Jon Husted hasn't led in a single recent poll against former senator Sherrod Brown, who lost by only three points in 2024.

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Iowa looks more vulnerable for Republicans than ever: The Republican and Democratic candidates have traded leads there in recent weeks, and the state's rural communities are especially vulnerable to hikes in diesel prices.

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In Alaska, Democrat Mary Peltola continues to lead in recent polling; even in polls in which she does not breach 50% in the first round, she beats incumbent Dan Sullivan in the state's ranked-choice system.

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In Maine, Susan Collins barely budged Democrat Troy Jackson's polling lead, though today's New York Times/Siena College poll is a positive sign for her. Given her state's trade exposure to Canada, the US-Canada trade war is eroding the key to her political longevity in the blue-leaning state: her longtime ability to demonstrate her independence from the White House.

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The Democrats' flanks in Minnesota, Georgia, New Hampshire, and Michigan are holding up, though Abdul El-Sayed in Michigan is the weakest of the four; North Carolina continues to look like a very likely Democratic flip.

The race is still close, and a Republican hold wouldn't surprise us. This is still structurally an extremely close race; small polling errors in only a few states would be enough for Republicans to hold on. The bull case for Republicans is the same as ever: The combination of massive October spending and Republican leaners coming home could just carry Republicans over the line. If the Democratic lead in the generic ballot falls back below six points or if Democrats lose their polling leads in enough states, we would shift our outlook.

The biggest difference between a split Congress and a unified Democratic one is nominations. Democratic control of the House was already going to paralyze the legislative agenda next year; a split Congress would accomplish only what it absolutely needs to, such as government funding and the debt ceiling, as well as limited work on rare areas of bipartisan priority, such as export controls. Democratic control of the Senate would make it more difficult—though not impossible—for the administration to confirm nominees to executive and judicial posts. In response, the White House will likely rely on acting and deputy secretaries to fill vacancies, and judicial nominations will mostly be stalled.

Winning the Senate this year would set Democrats up for a potential 2028 trifecta. Democrats have at least two pickup opportunities in 2028, in Wisconsin and North Carolina, while they will be defending vulnerable seats in Arizona, Nevada, Pennsylvania, and Georgia (and Ohio, if Brown wins there this

year). That is a relatively strong outlook for Democrats retaining the Senate in 2028 if a Democrat wins the presidency.

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